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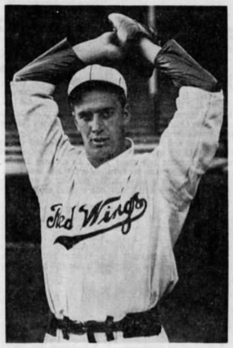
Heise, Fisher, Caldwell, Keane, Blair Other Entrants

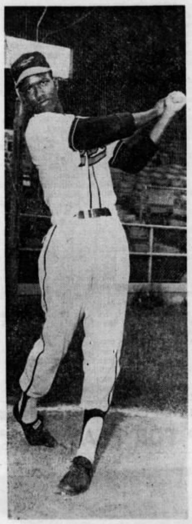
Jack Kimball Heads Parade of 6 into Elmira's Baseball Hall

JACK KIMBALL . . . One of the great pitchers

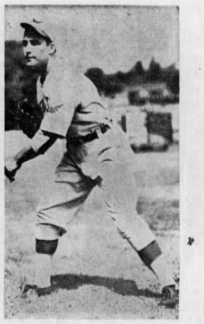
NEIL CALDWELL . . . Power at first



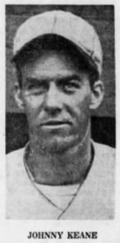
AL FISHER . . . Could throw—and hit



PAUL BLAIR . . . He was bat champ



LEFTY HEISE . . . 20-game winner



JOHNNY KEANE

By AL MALLETTE

Jack Kimball, the "Old Professor" of Elmira baseball, heads a parade of six ex-Elmira greats into the Elmira Baseball Hall of Fame this year.

Kimball totaled a record 366 ballots in the month-long poll conducted by Gary Girmindl, general manager of the Elmira Pioneers.

Joining Kimball in entry into the Hall this year are four other oldtimers and a relative "rookie."

Paul Blair, who won the Eastern League bat title and MVP award in 1964, is the rookie of the group. Paul today is an outfield star for the Baltimore Orioles.

The others were all old Red Wings, chattels of the St. Louis Cardinals' regime in Elmira in the 1932-34 era when Elmira housed several individual sparklers but failed to produce in the team won-lost column.

Matter of fact, the four entries probably are among the most popular players ever to wear an Elmira uniform. The group includes Clarence (Lefty) Heise, Al Fisher, Neil Caldwell and Johnny Keane.

The players will be honored at the Jan. 29 all - sports banquet.

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Heise, whose 20-8 record in Elmira in 1932 was his only 20-win season ever, was runnerup to Kimball in the voting with 345.

Caldwell, powerful first baseman for the 1933 and 1934 Red Wings, was next with 293 votes; followed by Blair with 293, Fisher with 246 and Keane with 229.

A total of 225 votes was the cutoff point for entry this year.

Those who just missed election were Clyde Parris, the hot shot third baseman of the 1953 Pioneers; Les Moss, star catcher of the 1943 Shaughnessy playoff victors; Dave Leonhard, 20-game winner of the 1965 club; Bob Wilson, third baseman for the 1950-51 teams; Eddie Robinson, first baseman for the 1941 champs; Ed Watt, double no-hit ace of the 1965 staff; and Rusty Saunders, .398 hitter of the 1930 Colonels.

Kimball, who carried the tag "professor" because he was an off - season school teacher, is one of Elmira's all - time pitching leaders. And, at 62 today, he's still teaching in Upper Darby, Pa.

Kimball came to Elmira in mid-season 1935 — the year that the independently - operated club had a team here, a team coming and a team going.

Kimball came from Wilkes-Barre in a cash deal and it proved one of the biggest bargains Levi Ginsberg and Bill Lande ever made.

Kimball finished 1935 with an 11-5 record for Elmira (He was 17-9 overall) and was 15-16 for Rabbit Maranville's second - half champs of 1936.

Kimball's greatest Elmira season was 1937 when he went 18-8 and was the pitching star of what many consider Elmira's greatest staff—Kimball, Lew Krausse, Bill Gilvary, John Hvisdos, Jack Casey, Bob Barr, Roger Hanlon.

Jack was 7-8 at mid-season 1938 when he was dealt back to Wilkes - Barre.

Kimball's overall Elmira record was 51-37.

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Heise, who started his career as a Cardinal farm hand at Topeka in 1928, came to Elmira in 1932 with John Mize and Buster Mills.

Lefty proceeded to waltz to a 20-8 season and led the then New York - Penn League in strikeouts with 187.

Heise later played at Columbus and Rochester, got a short shot with the St. Louis Cards, then a chronic sore arm forced an early retirement after the 1936 season.

Today Heise, the father of three and the grandpop of five, lives with his wife in Scottsdale, Pa. He's been with the Prudential Insurance Co. for 30 years.

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Fisher may possibly have been the best-hitting pitcher Elmira ever had — so strong that he might have ventured farther in baseball had he forsaken pitching for an outfield spot.

The only Elmira pitcher in memory who hit better than Handsome Al (he was the "doll" of the teams of 1932-33-34) was Alex Mustaikis in 1943.

Anyway, Fisher, a St. Louis native, arrived in Elmira shortly after Heise and the others in 1932.

The big righthander went 14-8 on the mound that season, went to the outfield on many off days and batted .308.

During 1933 Fisher spent more time in the outfield, hitting .316. But his pitching suffered to 5-6.

In 1934 Fisher went 12-10, batted .273 and smacked seven homers for a club which finished so deep in the basement that Elmira baseball officials got rid of the Cardinal chain and started the independent club of 1935.

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With two more of Fisher's 1934 teammates, Caldwell and Keane, voted in this year and two others, John Rizzo and Mort Cooper, already in the Hall, it's hard to figure why the club finished so deep in the basement — even if it was, as one oldtimer stated, "the year of the individualist, the year of the "Nightriders."

Caldwell hit .292 in 1933 and .325 in 1934.

He led the Pioneers in hits (154 and 177) both seasons, led in home runs (7-9) both seasons and led in RBI (78 and 94) both seasons.

Caldwell, a native of Nashville, Tenn., was the NY-P's all - league first baseman in 1934.

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Keane, too, was a 1934 all-star at shortstop.

He hit .300 for the season and when the season ended he headed up an Elmira Red Wing barnstorming troupe and played another month against industrial and town teams throughout the area.

Keane later became a manager in the St. Louis farm system, finally making the big club in the early 1960s. After leading the Cards to the 1964 pennant and World Series victory over the Yanks John became involved in one of the most bizarre incidents in the history of baseball.

The Yanks fired Yogi Berra as manager after the Series loss and Keane quit the Cardinals' helm and succeeded Berra as Yankee skipper.

Keane had all kinds of trouble as Yankee manager and was fired midway through the 1966 season. John died at his Texas home early this year.

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ELMIRA'S BASEBALL HALL
Former Players

Pete Reiser, Sal Maglie, Lew Krausse, John Mize, Irish Meusel, Steve O'Neill, Al Moore, Johnny Rizzo, George Staller, Don Zimmer, Packy Rogers, Zoilo Versalles, Jack Grossman, Mort Cooper, Leo Hanley, Andy Cohen, Ottie Johnson, Lefty Heffernan George Fallon, Gerry Hannahoe, Ted Pritchard, Alex Mustaikis, Ed Roebuck, Dave McNally, Fritz Werber, Jack Kimball, Clarence (Lefty) Heise, John Keane, Al Fisher, Neil Caldwell and Paul Blair.

Managers

Bruno Betzel, Mike O'Neill, Rabbit Maranville, Ray Brubaker, Clyde Sukeforth, Jake Pitler, Tommy Holmes, Earl Weaver, Darrell Johnson.

Elmirans Pro, Semi-Pro

John J. (Red) Murray, Jack Flynn, Tommy Thompson, Milt Paltrowitz, Al Todd, Brusie Ogrodowski, Frank (Yock) Robinson, Frank Bedenk, Don Richmond, Leo Ropelewski, Jim Walsh, Dan Richardson, Don (Toad) Walkker, Harold (Rabbit) Dunbar, Les Clute, King Diveny and Leon (Rope) Ropelewski.

Leaders of the Offense

Congdon, Bensley Cortland Sparklers

Special to
The Sunday Telegram

CORTLAND — Cortland's football Red Dragons will sit back and watch the 1967 gridiron season draw to a conclusion with some degree of satisfaction — particularly the faction from the Elmira area.

Although the Dragons were able to salvage only a 4-4 record out of what was supposed to be a banner year there are numerous reasons for Coach Roger Robinson to be optimistic about the future and even a little pleased with this year's results.

Don Congdon, a junior quarterback from Corning West High, led Robby's boys through their injury - plagued campaign and he did it with a lot of finesse and style.

In the process he erased just about every passing record on the Cortland books and then some. The blond physcial education major from Painted Post set new season records in total offense with 1,094 yards, passing yards with 1,030, pass attempts with 175, pass completions with 76, and touchdown passes with 9. He also estab-lsihed new single game standards with 193 yards in total offense against C. W. Post and 173 passing yards and 14 completions against the Long Islanders.

Robinson feels very fortunate to have had the services of Congdon through the season. He was hampered by a leg injury which slowed him up considerably the first half of the season but still did yeoman service.

Robby points out that "the proof of Donny's ability is his taking a team crippled with injuries to a 4-4 record. He was outstanding under terrific pressure. The Dragon mentor adds that Congdon is "a fine runner, a proven passer and a good team leader who shows a lot of poise."

Another bright spot in the Dragon picture this season was fullback Jim Bensley, a junior from Edison of Elmira Heights. The former Elmira All-City back from the Edison was handicapped by injuries early in the year but came on strong to finish as the team's rushing leader with a 3.9 yard average on 87 carries. Jim also kicked two field goals, scored two touchdowns and added three extra points to the Red Dragon season effort. Robinson says of the second year starter, "he does not have outstanding speed but Jim finds the hole and goes. He's a real strong, hard runner.

Vaughn Sherwood who played his high school ball at Elmira Free academy was a mainstay in the Cortland offensive forward wall until a late season injury sidelined the senior guard. Mike Hart another Elmira Free Academy graduate did most of the late season punting for the Red Dragons.

Don Congdon (left) chats with Cortland coach Rog Robinson.

JIM BENSLEY

St. Mary's Plans Athletic Assn.

St. Mary's is planning to organize an athletic association for the coming year. An open meeting is scheduled Wednesday night at 7:30 in the St. Mary's gym for all parents of Youth Organization members, plus other parrish members.

There's No Panic Despite Poor ABA Gates—Mikan

By LEW FERGUSON

MINNEAPOLIS (AP) — The new American Basketball Association is having attendance problems, Commissioner George Mikan readily admits, but he says they are predictable and there is no financial panic.

Citing such factors as "selling a new product," scheduling difficulties in areas in the 11 ABA cities and bucking football and hockey for the entertainment dollar early in the season, Mikan candidly admitted in an interview, "we knew we were going to have problems."

There is no talk of any teams folding or being transferred to other cities at the present time, Mikan said.

"It's been reported to me by the trustees of the league that they will operate for three years," Mikan said. "They are financially able to do so. Each team has posted a $100,000 bond to guarantee the complete operation for one year.

"Right now, we're in constant contact with all our people, and they are working toward getting past the football season. We want to get into the true basketball season to get a complete picture.

"We're cognizant of the fact that we're not drawing right now, but we're hopeful it will improve. We realize we have scheduling problems. We had to accept dates in arenas that were already full, and in many cases we were stuck with secondary dates.

"We are going to work toward having better scheduling dates next year. For example, Oakland is having to play a 39-game home schedule with only 42 dates available to play in its home arena. It's rather difficult to adjust this to 10 other cities. Next year, we'll get in there early enough to capture the right kind of dates.

"Another example of the prbolem is here in Minnesota. We are working against the Minnesota Vikings football and North Stars hockey. So we haven't been able to do what we want to do."

There is no need to discuss possible shifting of teams, Mikan said, because "everybody figures to stay put this year."

Mikan cited Denver as an example of what the ABA hopes to do in selling itself.

"Denver started out with 2,500 people for its home opener, then it went to 3,500 and then to somewhere around 4,000. Last week, they got up to 6,200, then dropped back to 3,800 when the Denver football team played the same day.

"When people start seeing how exciting our games are, we think they will come out. We knew we had a new product to sell, and we knew it wouldn't be easy."

McVea to Play in Shrine Game

SAN FRANCISCO (AP) — Two 9.5 dash men, Warren McVea of the University of Houston, and Haven Moses of San Diego State, will lend their talents to the West squad in the 43rd annual Shrine East-West football game Dec. 30.

Acceptance by running back McVea and flanker Moses were announced Saturday by Ted Balliest, potentate of Islam Temple, which founded the midwinter charity classic.

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Moses, 6-3 and 196 pounds, caught 62 passes for 102 yards and 10 touchdowns as a junior. So far in eight games, not counting Saturday's, he has "eased off" to 40 receptions for 720 yards and 5 touchdowns, but unbeaten San Diego hasn't been throwing as much as last year.

McVea is not so hefty, at 5-10 and 180 pounds, but Houston fans call him "Mac the Knife." Although out of two games with injuries, he won national back of the week honors for his share in the upset of Michigan State.

A third Shrine West back already in the fold is Lee White of Weber State. Standing 6-4 and weighing 238 pounds, he crunches up the middle and also goes wide. In eight games he has rushed for 1,236 yards.

Coach Raps Grid Polls

TALLAHASSEE, Fla. (AP) — Florida State University football coach Bill Peterson, stung because his squad is not ranked nationally, said he may go before the Football Coaches Association with a complaint about news service polls.

Peterson, in a news conference, said he felt a select committee could be named by the organization to look into the polls, determine what criteria are used and if certain guidelines should be established.

"I understand the system. But the system is not right," Peterson said.

The FSU Seminoles are 6-2-1, having won six straight after losses to Houston and North Carolina State and a tie with Alabama. North Carolina State was ranked No. 10 in The Associated Press poll this week. Houston and Alabama were not ranked.

Peterson said his squad, which he believes has the best passing game in the nation, is not ranked and the latest votes, leaving his team out after a 38-15 conquest of Virginia Tech, has his players mad.

FSU is a pass-oriented squad. Its quarterback Kim Hammond is ranked no. 1 nationally in total offense and flanker Ron Sellers is No. 1 in pass receptions.

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